

Ecumenism With Non Trinitarian Groups

Denial

doc-ecumenism-with-non-trinitarian-groups-denial
Inter-church Relations · Ecumenism · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants not in scope

Statement under examination

Groups that deny the Trinity are not Christian in the historical-creedal sense, and the Church's posture toward such groups is evangelism rather than ecumenical fellowship-union.

In plain language

Across several books the wording draws a line around who belongs to God by confession of the Son. First John 2:23 says plainly that everyone denying ('to deny' = arneomai) the Son does not even 'have' (echo) the Father, while the one confessing ('to confess' = homologeo) the Son has the Father also. The Greek sets two opposite words against each other, to deny and to confess, and uses a verb of having or not having a relationship, so a group that denies the Son is described as forfeiting the Father, not merely holding a different opinion. The denying word (arneomai) is common across the New Testament and consistently means contradicting Christ, so its sense is well anchored. John 5:23 reinforces this by setting equal honor ('to honor' = timao), that all should honor the Son ('Son' = huioi) just as they honor the Father ('Father' = pater), and that the one not honoring the Son does not honor the Father who sent him. The opening of John supplies the ground for that confession, naming the Word ('Word' = logos) as God ('God' = theos) who was with God. On posture the same circle of writings is concrete but narrower in wording. Second John tells readers not to 'receive' (lambano) into the house, and not even to 'greet' (chairo), anyone who does not bring 'the teaching' (didache) of Christ, and says that to greet such a person is to 'share or partner' (koinoneo) in his evil works. Second Corinthians uses a word that appears only once in the whole New Testament (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), meaning to be 'mismatched-yoked' (heterozygeo), to forbid binding partnership with unbelievers, then asks what fellowship light has with darkness and what concord Christ has with Belial. Galatians twice pronounces a curse ('curse, devotion to destruction' = anathema) on anyone who preaches a different gospel, even an angel from heaven. Taken together these terms support both halves of the proposition. The relational language of having the Father and of equal honor clearly marks denial of the Son as standing outside that relationship, and the commands not to receive, not to be yoked, and to treat a contrary gospel as accursed point toward separation and witness rather than binding union. The reason this lands at medium rather than full certainty is on the second half: the once-only yoke word, the way the receive and greet command targets welcoming a traveling teacher, and the unbeliever language of Second Corinthians leave open how far the separation reaches, even while no reading lets a denier of the Son be endorsed.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0331	ἀνάθεμα	anathema	devoted	7
G0720	ἀρνέομαι	arneomai	to deny	33
G1322	διδαχή	didache	teaching	30

G2086	ἐτεροζυγέω	heterozygeo	to yoke a mismatch	1
G2192	ἔχω	echo	to have/be	708
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,317
G2841	κοινωνέω	koinoneo	to participate	8
G2983	λαμβάνω	lambano	to take	258
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	330
G3326	μένω	meno	with/after	118
G3670	ὁμολογέω	homologeo	to confess/profess	26
G3962	πατήρ	pater	father	413
G5091	τιμάω	timao	to honor	21
G5207	υἱός	huios	son	386
G5463	χαίρω	chairō	to rejoice	74
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The identity half of the proposition is densely grounded. The articular present participle (a participle with the article 'the' attached, naming a settled type of person) 'the one denying' (ho arnoumenos) is a stable pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) category for contradicting Christ (33 occurrences of 'to deny' (arneomai) across 13 books), and 1 John 2:23 reads 'everyone denying the Son does not even have the Father' (pas ho arnoumenos ton huion oude ton patera echei), with 'to have or not have' (echo) framing a relationship and not a mere opinion. John 5:23 sets equal honor by the comparative 'just as' (kathos), 'that all may honor the Son just as they honor the Father' (hina pantes timosi ton huion kathos timosi ton patera), and John 1:1 predicates full deity of the Word, 'the Word was God' (theos en ho logos). The posture half rests on three converging texts that each carry a scope question: 2 John 10 commands 'do not receive him into a house' (me lambanete auton eis oikian), and 'do not greet' (me chairein), the one who does not abide in 'the teaching of Christ' (the didache tou Christou), and verse 11 makes greeting 'sharing' or 'partnering' (koinonei) in his evil works. 2 Corinthians 6:14 forbids being 'mismatched-yoked' (heterozygountes), but the verb is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible). Galatians 1:8-9 twice pronounces 'a curse, devotion to destruction' (anathema) on a different gospel. Both halves hold across multiple books, so the verdict affirms, but the posture vocabulary does not by itself fix how far the separation extends, which keeps confidence at medium.

Scripture

1John.2.22 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0720 ἀρνέομαι, G5207 υἱός, G3962 πατήρ

Force. The verse (1 John 2:22) twice uses the articular present participle (a participle with the article 'the' attached, naming a settled type of person) 'the one denying' (ho arnoumenos), first of denying that Jesus is the Christ and then of denying the Father and the Son together. The articular participle names a settled category of person, a teacher characterized by this denial, rather than a single lapse, and explicitly couples denial of the Son with denial of the Father. This identifies who stands on the wrong side of the confession.

1John.2.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0720 ἀρνέομαι, G3670 ὁμολογέω, G2192 ἔχω, G5207 υἱός, G3962 πατήρ

Force. 'Everyone denying the Son does not even have the Father' (pas ho arnoumenos ton huion oude ton patera echei), balanced by 'the one confessing the Son has the Father also' (ho homologon ton huion kai ton patera echei). The repeated verb 'to have' (echo), of having or not having the Father, makes the matter relational belonging, not mere opinion, and the antithesis of 'to deny' (arneomai) against 'to confess' (homologeio) sets denial and confession as the two exclusive sides, so a stance that denies the Son forfeits the Father by these terms.

John.1.1 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3056 λόγος, G2316 θεός

Force. 'And the Word was God' (kai theos en ho logos), with the anarthrous (without the article 'the') predicate 'God' (theos) placed before the copula (the linking verb 'is' or 'was') while the Word is also 'with the God' (pros ton theon), distinguishing the persons yet predicating full deity of the Word ('Word' = logos). This is the confession of the Son as God that the denial in 1 John and 2 John rejects.

John.1.18 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G3962 πατήρ

Force. The base text of John 1:18 reads 'the only-begotten God' (monogenes theos, where 'monogenes' means 'one-of-a-kind'), in the bosom of the Father ('Father' = pater), who has made him known. Father and Son are held together within the one Godhead, which is the joint relation that denial of the Son severs in 1 John 2:23.

John.5.23 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G5091 τιμάω, G5207 υἱός, G3962 πατήρ

Force. 'That all may honor the Son just as they honor the Father' (hina pantes timosi ton huion kathos timosi ton patera, where 'to honor' = timao), then 'the one not honoring the Son does not honor the Father who sent him' (ho me timon ton huion ou tima ton patera). The comparative 'just as' (kathos) sets the honor as equal, so withholding divine honor from the Son is withholding it from the Father, which places a group that does not so honor the Son outside right worship.

2John.1.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3670 ὁμολογέω

Force. 'Those not confessing Jesus Christ coming in flesh' (hoi me homologountes lesoun Christon erchomenon en sarki, where 'to confess' = homologeo) are named 'the deceiver and the antichrist' (ho planos kai ho antichristos). This is the immediate antecedent that defines the one barred from reception in verse 10, so the boundary in this letter is set by the specific confession of who Jesus Christ is.

2John.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3326 μένω, G1322 διδασκῆ, G2192 ἔχω

Force. 'Everyone going ahead and not abiding in the teaching of Christ does not have God' (pas ho proagon kai me menon en te didache tou Christou theon ouk echei, where 'to abide' = meno and 'teaching' = didache), while 'the one abiding in the teaching has both the Father and the Son' (ho menon en te didache). The 'having' idiom (echo, the verb of having or not having God) matches 1 John 2:23, and the genitive (the noun in the 'of-X' form) 'the teaching of Christ' (didache tou Christou) ties belonging to fidelity to the apostolic teaching about him.

2John.1.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2983 λαμβάνω, G5463 χαίρω, G1322 διδαχή

Force. 'Do not receive him into a house and do not say a greeting to him' (me lambanete auton eis oikian kai chairein auto me legete, where 'to receive' = lambano and 'to greet/rejoice' = chairo), two present imperatives (ongoing commands) with 'do not' (me) forbidding ongoing reception and the customary greeting toward anyone who does not bring this teaching (didache). The verbs concern hospitality and welcome of a traveling teacher, which is a concrete refusal of fellowship toward those who reject the teaching of Christ.

2John.1.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5463 χαίρω, G2841 κοινωνέω

Force. 'The one greeting him shares in his evil works' (ho legon gar auto chairein koinonei tois ergois autou tois ponerois, where 'to greet' = chairo). The verb 'to partner or share' (koinoneo) frames even a greeting as participation, and the same verb in 1 Timothy 5:22 warns against sharing in others' sins, so the lexical sense is consistent, treating welcome of such teaching as complicity.

2Cor.6.14 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2086 ἐτεροζυγέω

Force. 'Do not become mismatched-yoked with unbelievers' (me ginesethe heterozygountes apistois, where 'mismatched-yoked' = heterozygeo), a single rare verb, a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in the canon, built on the image of yoking unlike animals, followed by the rhetorical pairs asking what 'fellowship' (koinonia) light has with darkness and what concord Christ has with Belial. The figure presses incompatibility of binding partnership, supporting separation, but the verb occurs only once so its precise scope, every binding tie or a narrower set, cannot be triangulated from canon usage.

2Cor.6.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5547 Χριστός

Force. 'What concord has Christ with Belial' (tis de symphonesis Christou pros Beliar, where 'Christ' = Christos), and what 'share' (meris) has a 'believer' (pistos) with an 'unbeliever' (apistos). The series opposes Christ to Belial and the believing to the unbelieving, reinforcing incompatibility, with the explicit scope being the believer set against the unbeliever set.

Gal.1.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0331 ἀνάθεμα

Force. 'Even if we or an angel from heaven preaches a gospel other than what we preached, let him be a curse' (kan hemeis e angelos ex ouranou euangelizetai par ho euangelisametha hymin, anathema esto, where 'curse, devotion to destruction' = anathema). The term 'curse' (anathema) marks devotion to destruction, the strongest possible separation, and the reach even to an angel removes any appeal to messenger authority.

Gal.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0331 ἀνάθεμα

Force. 'If anyone preaches to you a gospel other than what you received, let him be a curse' (ei tis hymas euangelizetai par ho parelabete, anathema esto, where 'curse' = anathema), repeated with 'again' (palin). Doubling the 'curse' (anathema) and broadening from 'we' to 'anyone' sets it as a standing rule rather than a single-case exception against a contrary gospel about Christ.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.5.23	1John.2.23	openbible	26

1John.2.23	John.5.23	openbible	14
1John.2.23	1John.4.15	openbible	17
1John.2.23	John.10.30	openbible	13
1John.2.23	2John.1.9	openbible	10
2John.1.9	John.7.16	openbible	25
2John.1.9	1John.2.22	openbible	13
John.1.1	Rev.19.13	openbible	226
John.1.1	Col.1.17	openbible	221
John.5.23	Luke.10.16	openbible	21

Complicating texts

John.17.21 · addressed

The prayer 'that they may all be one' (hina pantes hen osin) is invoked for cross-confessional union. Within the same Johannine vocabulary, the oneness asked is grounded in the Father and Son relation, 'just as you Father are in me' (kathos su pater en emoi), and is sought for those who believe through the apostolic word, verse 20, 'those believing through their word' (ton pisteuonton dia tou logou auton). The unity term 'one' (hen) here is given a confessional ground in the same author who in 1 John and 2 John makes denial of the Son forfeit the Father, so the prayer qualifies but does not cancel that boundary.

John.13.34 · addressed

The command 'love one another' (agapate allelous) is read by some as overriding separation. The reciprocal pronoun 'one another' (allelous) has internal scope, fellow disciples, and 2 John holds love and refusal of reception together in one short letter, so love of brethren does not cancel the 'do not receive' (me lambanete) toward those who deny the teaching of Christ.

Mark.9.40 · addressed

'Whoever is not against us is for us' (hos gar ouk estin kath hemon hyper hemon estin) is read as broad inclusion. The saying concerns one casting out demons 'in your name' (en to onomati sou), that is acting under the name rather than denying it, so it does not reach groups that deny the Son, whom 1 John 2:23 places outside having the Father.

2Cor.6.14 · addressed

The prohibition 'mismatched-yoked with unbelievers' (heterozygountes apistois) explicitly addresses the believer and unbeliever pairing, not relations among those who already confess Christ, and the key verb is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible). The proposition applies it to groups that deny the Trinity by treating such deniers as among the 'unbelievers' (apistoi), but the single occurrence of the verb means the breadth of binding partnership it forbids cannot be fixed from canon usage alone, which is noted rather than resolved by appeal to one verse.

Concordance traversed

G0720, G3670, G2192, G5091, G5207, G3962, G3056, G3326, G1322, G2983, G5463, G2841, G2086, G0331, G2316, G5547

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Jn1.18-monogenes at John.1.18: impact none. The base text of John 1:18 reads 'only-begotten God' (monogenes theos, where 'monogenes' means 'one-of-a-kind'), with 'only-begotten Son' (monogenes huios) attested in other

witnesses. Either reading keeps the Son within the Godhead alongside the Father, so the verdict on identity is unaffected.

The cited verses lie outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample and the bundle reports 'not_in_ecm_scope', so no ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) was consulted. The one substantive reading touched, 'only-begotten God' (monogenes theos) versus 'only-begotten Son' (monogenes huios) at John 1:18, does not alter the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

confessional-boundary: affirms · Reading the Johannine 'having' idiom (echo, of having or not having the Father), the 'to deny' (arneomai) against 'to confess' (homologeo) antithesis, and the 'to honor' (timao) parity of John 5:23 yields a confession-bounded identity, so denial of the Son severs the relation to the Father. The posture texts, 2 John 10-11 'do not receive' (me lambanete) and 'shares/partners' (koinonei), 2 Corinthians 6:14 'mismatched-yoked' (heterozygeo), and the doubled 'curse' (anathema) of Galatians 1:8-9, then direct separation and witness rather than binding union, matching both halves of the proposition.

ecumenical-inclusivist: complicates · A lens prioritizing visible unity reads John 17:21 'that they may all be one' (hina pantes hen osin) and the broad love commands as warrant for fellowship across confessional lines, and notes that the 2 John commands address hospitality to itinerant teachers, 'receive into a house' (lambano eis oikian), and that 2 Corinthians 6:14 names the 'unbelievers' (apistoi), so they need not on their own face settle every form of ecumenical relation. On the lexical terms this reading must still account for the explicit 'do not receive' (me lambanete), the 'shares/partners' (koinonei) warning, and the doubled 'curse' (anathema), which constrain how far the unity texts can stretch.

scope-restrictive: disputed · A reading attentive to vocabulary scope grants the identity half, deny the Son and you do not have the Father, but holds that the posture half is underdetermined, since 'mismatched-yoked' (heterozygeo) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) whose breadth cannot be triangulated, the 2 John reception language concerns receiving a teacher into a house and greeting, and 'the teaching of Christ' (didache tou Christou) could be read as Christ's own teaching, John 7:16, or teaching about Christ. On this lens the words clearly forbid endorsing a denier, but do not by themselves fix whether all ecumenical contact, or only partnership that endorses, is barred.

The verdict rests on the canon interpreting the canon, joining the Johannine denial, confession, and honor language with the Johannine reception commands and the Pauline yoke and 'curse' (anathema) language. The proposition phrase 'Christian in the historical-creedal sense' is treated as a label and set aside, and the verdict is derived from the lexical relation terms themselves.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Whether the New Testament places groups that reject the deity of the Son outside those it describes as having the Father, and whether its vocabulary directs separation and witness rather than binding fellowship toward such groups.

The stem phrase 'not Christian in the historical-creedal sense' imports a later credal taxonomy, and the contrast evangelism rather than ecumenical fellowship-union frames the expected answer. The verdict was derived on the original stem but tested against the neutral rephrasing, which the lexical relation terms support directly: 'to deny' (arneomai) against 'to confess' (homologeo), 'to have' (echo) of having or not having the Father, the 'just as' (kathos) honor parity, 'do not receive' (me lambanete), 'to partner or share' (koinoneo) as sharing, 'mismatched-yoked' (heterozygeo), and the doubled 'curse' (anathema). The same audit surfaces the genuine scope gap that holds confidence at medium, since the identity terms are decisive but the posture terms include a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) and reception language whose breadth the words do not fix.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.2.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2John.1.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2John.1.10
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.6.14
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.1.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.5.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.1.1
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2086
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0331
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0720
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2841
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	John.5.23
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	2John.1.9

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

cross-tradition-divergent